

AI POLITICS



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THE POWER AND PERILS OF AI-DRIVEN ELECTIONS

AI CAN REVOLUTIONISE ELECTION CAMPAIGN STRATEGIES, PERSONALISE VOTER OUTREACH AND EVEN INFLUENCE PUBLIC OPINION. BUT THE POTENTIAL BENEFITS COME WITH SERIOUS RISKS THAT NEED TO BE ADDRESSED

Bharat's vibrant democracy is on the cusp of a profound transformation driven by Artificial Intelligence. Many new applications, driven by AI, are rapidly seeping into the fabric of everyday life, and elections are no exception. From micro-targeting voters to manipulating public opinion, AI has the potential to reshape the entire election landscape, presenting both opportunities and challenges for Bharatiya democracy.

One of the most significant impacts of AI is its ability to micro-target voters with laser precision. This involves using vast amounts of data, including demographics, social media activity and online behaviour, to build detailed profiles of individual voters. These profiles are then used to deliver personalised content, advertisements and messages that resonate with their specific interests and concerns. Unlike traditional broad-brush campaigning, AI-powered micro-targeting allows for tailored strategies that can be far more effective in swaying voters.

We have already seen multiple applications of AI-driven analytics. For instance, Cambridge Analytica, a political consulting firm, utilised data scraped from millions of Facebook profiles to build detailed psychological profiles of voters. They used this information to target these voters with personalised ads and messages on social media, potentially influencing their voting decisions during the 2016 US presidential elections.

But AI is not just about delivering the right message to the right person; it can also influence how that message is perceived. Deepfakes—manipulated videos that seem real—can be used to create false narratives and smear campaigns against